1.1 Expanding Democracy

You back the candidate who's got your back. It's human nature. He or she supports your causes and promises to fix all the things you think are broken. Of course, these promises aren't always kept.

MAIN IDEA Regional differences fueled a battle over the presidency in the 1820s between John Quincy Adams and Andrew Jackson.

THE TIGHT ELECTION OF 1824

The presidential election of 1824 pitted **John Quincy Adams**, the current secretary of state and son of John Adams, against Andrew Jackson, who, as you may remember, fought in the War of 1812. The two candidates embodied the regional differences that divided the country. Adams represented the businessmen of the East. He wanted to build canals and roads to improve the nation's transportation system, and he promoted science and education. Jackson, representing the farmers of the West, supported states' rights. Adams and Jackson were the main candidates in 1824, but other candidates ran as well, including William Crawford, the secretary of the treasury, and Henry Clay, the speaker of the House of Representatives.

Andrew Jackson received the most popular votes in the election by a large margin. He also won the most electoral votes. However, he failed to win more than half of the total electoral votes, which then, as now, is required for victory. As a result, according to the 12th Amendment to the Constitution, the responsibility of choosing a winner among the top three candidates—Jackson, Adams, and Crawford—fell to the House of Representatives. By one vote, the House chose Adams to lead the country.

Adams took office in March 1825 and appointed Henry Clay as the secretary of state shortly thereafter. The appointment outraged Jackson. He believed that Adams and Clay had made a deal in which Clay persuaded other members of the House to vote for Adams in exchange for the prestigious, or highly respected, cabinet position. Jackson called the deal a "corrupt bargain" and claimed the men stole the election from him. As president, Adams didn't gather much backing for his proposed canals and roads, in part because Jackson's supporters in Congress blocked them.

READY FOR A REMATCH

Meanwhile, Jackson had his eyes on the 1828 presidential election. Both Adams and Jackson were Democratic-Republicans, but the party had become deeply split. According to Jackson, on one side stood Adams and the rich easterners whose interests Adams favored. Jackson himself claimed to champion hardworking people whom he called the "common man." Eventually, two new parties arose. Adams and his followers formed the **National Republicans.** Jackson and his camp were known as **Democrats**.

During the 1828 campaign, both parties used speeches, parades, **slogans**, or sayings, and songs to build excitement for their candidate—an approach that changed the way politicians ran for office. Supporters on both sides also took part in mudslinging, or using insults to attack an opponent. In spite of all the name-calling, Jackson easily beat Adams in the election.

Voting rights, or laws that dictate which Americans have the right to vote, had been extended so more people could vote. You may recall that previously, only white men who owned property and paid taxes could vote. By contrast, in 1828, most white men in many states could vote whether they owned property or not. As a result, about 782,000 more "common men" participated in the 1828 election than in the previous one. Most Americans viewed Jackson's win as a victory over the privileged. **Jacksonian democracy** was the

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A GLOBAL PERSPECTIVE Andrew Jackson extended voting rights to more white men in 1828. The Americans who still could not vote, however, would have to fight for many years to gain that right. In some countries today, people still do not have the vote. In others, that right has been reinstated following the overthrow of repressive governments.

In the photos below, for example, an Iraqi man, an Afghan woman, and a Pakistani woman hold up their inked fingers, which indicate that they have voted after their right to vote was reinstated in the 21st century. In the large photo taken in 1994, black South Africans wait in a long line to vote in the first fully democratic election in the country.

political movement that celebrated the common man—farmers, craftsmen, laborers, and middle-class businessmen—and defended the will of the people. But women, African Americans, and Native Americans still could not vote or hold office. Nevertheless, Jackson's election in 1828 reflected the steady expansion of white male suffrage, symbolized the shift of political power to the West, and opened a new era of political democracy in the United States. President Jackson was a symbol of his age. People now believed they were represented by one of their own in the White House.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How was the presidential election of 1824 decided?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** How was Jacksonian democracy different from what had existed before?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** Why was Jacksonian democracy such an important development?

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